

ONCE BITTEN, TWICE SHY:
(From left) Congress leaders
Mallikarjuna Kharge, Janardhan
Poojary and Dharam Singh



“Gowda doesn’t keep his word at all and has a forked tongue.”

D.K. SHIVAKUMAR, CONGRESS LEADER

Kumaraswamy in the Sathanur assembly seat in 1999. After the delimitation commission recently knocked off Sathanur from the assembly map, Shivakumar—who has been an active MLA from Sathanur—suspected the hand of the Gowda family in this. Says Shivakumar, “He will go to any length to have his family stay in power.”

The farmer can be a fighter too. He took on Infosys founder and chief mentor N.R. Narayana Murthy and Ashok Kheny, the promoter of the Rs 3,500-crore Bangalore Mysore Infrastructure Corridor alleging that they were only interested in grabbing land. “I will oppose this (corridor) as it goes against the wishes of the people, I am fighting for the farmers who have lost their land in this project,” said Gowda. Kheny, who divides his time between his home in the US and Bangalore, has won nearly 300 court cases against the project over the past 11 years. Says Kheny, “Gowda is selfish and is only bothered about himself and his family, not the welfare of the state.”

During his short tenure as prime minister in 1996-97, Gowda was considered a successor to Charan

Singh and Devi Lal as the voice of rural India, the country’s peasant-in-chief. The epithet *mannina maga*—son of the soil—came to be linked to Gowda because of his penchant for anything rustic. “His biggest mantra for success is that he always keeps talking about the farmers and his heart is there,” says son Revanna.

Today he thinks he has another, more provincial role to play. Gowda also sees his family as the key protectors of the Vokkaliga movement, the

state’s second largest community comprising 16 per cent of the six crore population. His hometown is not far from his mind either. Gowda ensured his home district Hassan got taken care of during the Dharam Singh regime. Revanna earmarked Rs 200 crore as development package for the family’s native district. And last month, the father and son showed up in full strength to inaugurate a massive airport project in Hassan promoted by their new friend and Rajya Sabha MP Rajeev Chandrashekhkar.

Gowda’s partymen are disappointed that he did not honour the pact between his son, and BJP had a groundswell of sympathy, especially from the state’s largest caste bloc, the Lingayats. “We are ready to face the people and tell them the real story,” says Gowda. But chief minister hopeful B.S. Yediyurappa of BJP says, “The people of Karnataka will teach these betrayers a costly lesson. They don’t know how to keep a word, to honour an agreement, a gentleman’s agreement.”

Gentleman? This farmer is more of a foxy family man. ■



CENTRE’S MAN:
Governor Rameshwar Thakur